

taught.

Subverting tradition

With such an unorthodox musical upbringing, he inevitably gravitated toward the unconventional, and in 1951, he cofounded a group of avant-garde artists, writers, and musicians known as Jikken Kōbō (Experimental Workshop), who rejected the traditional academic arts. For Takemitsu, this was a conscious turning away from Japanese tradition, which for him had only negative associations. Instead, he found inspiration in Debussy's Impressionism, and in the 12-tone serial compositions of Webern and later Messiaen. A turning point came when Stravinsky heard Takemitsu's 1957 Requiem for string orchestra, and his enthusiasm for it helped publicize Takemitsu in the West. Around this time, Takemitsu discovered the experimental music of John Cage. He became interested in Cage's use of indeterminacy and chance in composition, and the idea of silence as a dynamic element. Ironically, it was this US composer's work that prompted Takemitsu to reexamine Japanese traditional music, which shares many of Cage's ideals. He began studying Japanese music and its instruments, trying to find a way of integrating them into his Western musical style.

His first major work in this vein was November Steps for biwa (a traditional Japanese lute), shakuhachi (a flute), and orchestra, premiered in 1967. During the 1970s and 1980s, a catalog of compositions appeared in which Takemitsu refined his style, combining Japanese and Western elements to varying degrees. The aim in his later works was to create a "sea of tonality," a